IDENTIFYING A SPELL (5E, 2024 RULES) – DESCRIPTION

Many spells come with **obvious effects**: fiery explosions, walls of ice, teleportation. Others, like **Charm Person**, have no visible, audible, or perceptible sign: those who are not affected probably don't notice them. In general, you don't know a spell was cast unless it produces a noticeable effect.

🎲 Quick summary: identifying a spell

1. Only a **non-instantaneous** spell whose duration is ongoing can be identified.
2. You identify it by its **observable effects**.
3. You must take the **Study** action.
4. Succeed on an **Intelligence (Arcana)** check, **DC 15**.

⚠ Noticing a spellcaster: Table rule

- To be noticeable, the casting must include a **Verbal**, **Somatic**, or **Material** component. The form of the Material component doesn't matter.
- If the caster can do without components (a Sorcerer's **Subtle Spell**, innate spellcasting of many creatures), the casting is imperceptible.
- If an imperceptible casting produces a noticeable effect, you normally can't tell who cast the spell without other clues.

⚠ Change from 2014

Identification goes through the **Study** action with a fixed DC of 15, and only for an **ongoing** spell.

⚠ Flaw in the rule and fixes Table rule

An instantaneous spell (like **Fireball**) can't be identified by this rule, yet players often want to know what was just cast. Fix: the **DM describes the effects**, or allows the table method on the How to play page.

💡 Narrative option: Table rule

The DM can describe the casting's signature without naming the spell: whispered words, precise gestures, a glow on the focus, a whiff of sulfur, a chill in the air.

Step 1 – Notice the casting: Table rule

An observer notices a spell being cast if they hear the words (Verbal), see the gestures (Somatic), or see the Material component.

Step 2 – Imperceptible casting: Table rule

If the caster does without components (Subtle Spell, innate spellcasting), nobody notices the casting. If the effect is visible, it is hard to tell who cast it.

Step 3 – Observe the effects:

An explosion or a wall of ice is noticed at once. A spell with no visible effect, like Charm Person, goes unnoticed by those who are not affected.

Step 4 – Identify an ongoing spell:

The spell must be **non-instantaneous** and its duration ongoing. You take the **Study** action and succeed on an **Intelligence (Arcana)** DC 15 check.

Example: a mage maintains a Web spell. Léa (Arcana +5) studies its effects and rolls 10: 10 + 5 = 15, she identifies the spell.

Table rule: instantaneous spells and observed casting Table rule

The author's proposal, absent from the SRD. The DM announces it before the game.

- **When**: as a reaction during the casting, or with an action on your turn after the casting.
- **Condition**: the character perceived the casting, the spell's effect, or both.
- **Check**: Intelligence (Arcana), DC 15 + the spell's level.

Common table questions.

What about a magic or cursed item?

This sheet covers **spells** only. To learn an item's properties, its attunement, or its curse, see the **Identifying a Magic Item** sheet.

Can I identify Fireball?

Not with the Study action: the spell is instantaneous. The DM describes the effects, or applies the table rule. Table rule

Do I need to see the caster?

You need to perceive the observable effect of the ongoing spell. To notice the casting itself, see the How to play page.

What is a "non-instantaneous" spell?

A spell whose duration is not Instantaneous (Concentration, minutes, hours…) and that is still active.

Does the DC change with the spell's level?

Not in 2024: the DC is a flat 15. With the table rule, it becomes 15 + the spell's level. Table rule

⚠ Rule clarifications (answers found on the web, reworded):

Telling if an effect is magical

The game text says whether an effect is magical. Effects from spells and magic items always are.

Class spells

A spell is a class spell only if it appears on that class's list, unless a feature says otherwise.

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